had China embarked on a long military modernization program, but it had steadily begun to increase its military presence in the South and East China Seas, as well as venturing into the Indian Ocean and western Pacific. It had also begun to use its military to back up its various territorial claims in some of those same waters. But what caught regional attention in particular was China's dramatic land reclamation and island-building campaign among reefs and atolls in disputed waters in the Spratly and Paracel Islands in the South China Sea during the mid-2010s. It seemed Beijing was actively, even physically, changing the balance of power in the region, discarding international law and postwar norms, and ignoring the claims of smaller Southeast Asian nations to some of the same territory. It was, perhaps, the "Sputnik moment" for America's Asia policy.

Starting in 2014 or so, publicly available satellite photography dramatically showed that what had been largely underwaters reefs just a few years prior were now islands.[4] Moreover, the nearly three thousand acres of reclaimed land on China's new territory were being fortified with airfields, hangars, radars, and other support buildings. Admiral Harris called this China's "great wall of sand," even as Beijing repeatedly asserted that the islands would not be used for military purposes. Evidence soon emerged that the People's Liberation Army (PLA) had landed advanced fighter jets and strategic bombers, and emplaced surface-to-air missiles, on Woody Island in the disputed Paracel island chain. Subsequent months revealed the fortification of Fiery Cross Reef and other Chinese-claimed isles in the South China Sea.[5] As Harris testified, "You'd have to believe in a flat Earth" not to see that China was indeed militarizing the South China Sea.[6] China's rapid and assertive building up of its military capabilities in one of the world's most vital waterways stoked wide-ranging concerns about the balance of power, Beijing's intentions, and America's ability to remain the predominant power in the Indo-Pacific region.

Washington was not blind to the implications of Beijing's actions. Starting in the early 2010s, a prolonged American debate began on how